

Pocket

UX/UI Case Study — Personal Finance & Budgeting App

AI-Enhanced Design · iOS + Responsive Web · Coded HTML/CSS/JS Prototype

Designer	Yasir Afaque
Timeline	January 2026 — February 2026
Tools	Figma · AI-assisted research (Claude, ChatGPT) · HTML / CSS / JavaScript
Platform	iOS Mobile App + Responsive Website (3 breakpoints)
Deliverables	Hi-fi Figma prototype + Fully coded interactive website (16 screens)
Status	Hi-fi complete · Coded website live · Usability testing complete (5 participants)

1. Overview

Pocket is a mobile app, responsive website, and fully coded interactive prototype designed to solve a universal problem: not knowing where your money goes. Unlike every competitor, Pocket adapts its budgeting model to how users actually earn — salary, allowance, freelance, or pension — making it the first personal finance tool structurally inclusive of students, freelancers, couples, and retirees.

A fully coded interactive website was built in HTML, CSS, and JavaScript alongside the Figma prototype. A moderated usability study with 5 participants produced P0/P1/P2 findings that directly shaped the second iteration — most significantly replacing the floating action button for expense entry after all 5 participants failed to find it.

AI tools (Claude and ChatGPT) were used to accelerate persona research, synthesise competitive audit findings across 14 criteria, and identify structural gaps in competitor products.

2. The Problem

Every major personal finance app is built for one user type: a salaried adult with stable monthly income. This excludes the majority of the global population:

- Students and irregular earners — monthly-salary apps are architecturally incompatible with weekly allowances
- Couples and shared households — shared budgets locked behind premium subscriptions everywhere
- Older users and retirees — need savings runway tools, not growth projections
- Gig economy workers — daily variable income with no app designed for their model

AI-assisted competitive analysis (Claude auditing five major apps against 14 criteria) confirmed: no competitor supports variable income natively, offers shared budgets for free, or provides a savings runway calculator. These three gaps became Pocket’s core differentiators.

3. The Solution

Design Pillar	What It Does	AI Integration
Income mode selector	Sets entire budget model at onboarding (Salary/Allowance/Freelance/Pension)	AI recommends category presets by income mode
Visual spending dashboard	Chart-first category breakdown and savings progress at a glance	AI surfaces spending anomalies and pattern insights
Two-tap expense entry	Log any expense in under 5 seconds — amount and category only	AI auto-suggests category from description text
Savings goal tracker	Visual progress bars with optional auto-transfer	AI projects goal completion date from savings rate
Smart contextual alerts	Specific next-action suggestions, not just percentage warnings	AI generates personalised actionable recommendations
Savings runway (pension)	Shows how long savings last at current rate	AI adjusts projection for healthcare cost inflation
Shared budget (free)	Free shared space for couples and households	AI detects unusual shared spending patterns

The coded website covers all 16 screens: landing, income mode onboarding, sign up/in, dashboard, budget, add expense (with working numpad), transactions, saving goals, shared budget, monthly report, profile, and 404 page — all fully navigable.

4. Design Process

4.1 Empathize

Persona	Age	Occupation	Location	Core Challenge
Maya Chen	26	Software Engineer	Taipei, Taiwan	Earns well; no idea where money goes each month
James Okafor	22	University Student	Lagos, Nigeria	Allowance runs out; irregular income structure
Sarah Mitchell	34	Freelance Designer	London, UK	Variable income makes fixed budgets useless
Ravi & Priya Sharma	38/35	Accountant & Teacher	Mumbai, India	No free shared budget tool for couples

Persona	Age	Occupation	Location	Core Challenge
Eleanor Brooks	62	Retired Teacher	Melbourne, Australia	Fixed pension; needs savings runway not growth
Kevin Adeyemi	29	Gig Economy Driver	Nairobi, Kenya	Daily variable income; no app built for this
Fatima Al-Rashid	41	Part-time retail + single parent	Riyadh, Saudi Arabia	Two children; no Arabic budgeting tool available

4.2 Define

Problem statement: People at every income level and life stage need a budgeting tool that adapts to how they actually earn money — not how finance apps assume they earn. Monthly-salary apps structurally exclude students, freelancers, gig workers, couples, and retirees.

4.3 Competitive Audit

Feature	Mint	YNAB	Money Manager	Spendee	Pocket
Variable income	No	Partial	No	No	Yes — income modes
Onboarding time	5–10 min	15–20 min	< 2 min	3–5 min	< 3 min
Shared budget free	No	Paid only	No	Paid only	Yes
Savings runway	No	No	No	No	Yes
AI-powered insights	No	No	No	No	Yes

4.4 Prototype & Code

Lo-fi wireframes → Hi-fi Figma → Coded HTML/CSS/JS website. Bold red (#C0392B) primary, dark navy text, Inter typography. The coded prototype includes a working numpad for expense entry, filterable transaction list, savings goal progress bars, shared budget settle-up flow, and monthly SVG trend chart.

4.5 Usability Testing Results

Priority	Issue	Evidence	Fix Applied
P0 — Critical	Add Expense button not found	5/5 missed FAB; P4 scrolled looking for 'add'; P5 tapped chart	Sticky 'Add expense' button above nav bar
P0 — Critical	Income mode options not understood	3/5 unsure which applied to them; 2 abandoned onboarding	Plain-English descriptions + 'You can change this later' label

Priority	Issue	Evidence	Fix Applied
P1 — Important	Budget categories too generic	Could not map real spending to defaults	Allow custom category naming in setup
Strength	Chart-first dashboard	Praised by all 5 participants for immediate clarity	Preserved and made primary in iteration 2

5. Key Design Decisions

5.1 Income Mode Selector

The single most important design decision. By asking how users earn money upfront, every subsequent screen adapts — budget targets, alert thresholds, savings projections, and even UI copy. Freelancers get weekly cycles; students get allowance tracking; retirees get savings runway calculators. No competitor does this.

5.2 AI-Powered Spending Insights

Rather than passive notifications, Pocket uses AI to generate contextual next-action recommendations. The AI layer was designed to feel like a knowledgeable friend, not a bank dashboard.

5.3 Shared Budget as a Free Feature

Every competitor locks shared mode behind a paid plan. Pocket offers it free — a direct response to the competitive audit finding that couples are entirely excluded from free tiers everywhere.

5.4 Coded Prototype

The HTML/CSS/JS prototype serves three purposes: demonstrating design-to-development translation, enabling realistic usability testing, and functioning as a live stakeholder demo. The onboarding flow correctly routes Sign Up → Income Mode → Category Setup → Dashboard.

6. Outcomes & Next Steps

Deliverable	Status	Detail
Figma hi-fi prototype	Complete	16 screens, full design system, all links active
Coded website (HTML/CSS/JS)	Complete	All 16 screens fully navigable with interactive components
UX research document	Complete	7 personas, journey maps, competitive audit
Moderated usability study	Complete	5 participants, 2 P0 issues resolved in iteration 2
AI spending insights layer	Planned	Pattern detection as working API demonstration
Dark theme variant	Planned	Matching SchoolRoute dark system for user preference
Bank API integration design	Planned	Trust and permission flow for account linking